

Unit 5**Leading****Structure:**

- 5.1 Introduction, Objectives
- 5.2 Case Study
- 5.3 Definition and Comparison and Contrasting of Directing and Leading
- 5.4 Characteristics of Leading
- 5.5 Importance of Leading
- 5.6 Functions of Leading
- 5.7 Summary
- 5.8 Glossary
- 5.9 Terminal Questions
- 5.10 Answers

5.1 Introduction

In the previous unit, we dealt with the definition and importance of organising, types of organisations and departmentation, organisational division, and span of control. We also analysed staffing and its importance, line concept, and staff concept.

In the manufacturing economy, once people have been positioned to do various activities, the next step was to pass instructions to the people on how to accomplish a task. This worked well in large factory floors. But, when the service economy set in, direction-giving underwent a change. Here, people had a different meaning since they had to take their own initiatives to do tasks if the company had to be competitive. In due course, the need for innovation and continuous improvement compelled even large manufacturing shop floors to shift to leading than directing. Organisations where shop floor or front-end managers showed leading capability became more competitive and then the management thinkers took note of this fact and felt that leading rather than directing was necessary for the organisation. It also brought to the fore the importance of every manager being a leader, which is perhaps the reason why in organisations we hear so much about leadership. An element of power and authority is vested in every job as we saw in the unit 'organising'. However, the power so vested is insufficient to get the best out of people. Therefore, though the

managers have vested powers, they have to rise above it and become leaders. In this unit, we will deal with the process of leading. As a precondition, we must accept the notion that all of us are destined to lead in an organisation in some or the other form even if we are doing a job, which is relatively low in hierarchy.

Objectives:

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- To differentiate between leading and directing.
- To determine the characteristics of leading.
- To describe the importance of leading
- To acquire knowledge about the functions of leading.

Learning Outcomes

After studying this unit, you will be able to:

- define and differentiate between leading and directing.
- state the characteristics of leading.
- describe the importance of leading.
- list the functions of leading

5.2 Case Study**Sambhavi Bakers Part II**

If you recall, Mrs. Rakhi and her daughter were in a quandary about the expansion plan of Sambhavi Bakers to the neighbouring districts. At last in 2005 February, they took the plunge and opened four outlets one after the other. Mrs. Rakhi had thought that if she did not expand to that level in the first go, the economies of scale will not work out and all the money she sinks to overcome the logistic and managerial expertise deficiency will not yield results. All the outlets were 70 to 100 km from Salem. They were located in upper middle class residential environment and had facilities for a casual snack meal. The places were aesthetic and to attract the crowd she pushed in some fashion merchandise of ladies fashion clothes, handicrafts, children's educational toys, video games, and more importantly a caretaker where the parents could leave the child while they enjoyed a bite.

Mrs. Rakhi divided each of her outlets into various functional units such as confectionary selling units, snack meal unit, merchandising unit,

gaming unit, and kid care support unit. Each of them had a head at her head office in Salem and she took care to hire a child psychologist as the head of kid care support unit. All units, except the kid care unit had its own objective and targets. Each centre had a manager and each function except the kid care had an Assistant Manager as its head. The care taker was trained by the child psychologists and replete with modern and educational toys. This actually became the biggest attraction though it was a free service. But she did not mind as the parents thronged to the place and spent considerable money in her confectionary. She gave considerable freedom to her managers to innovate and rewarded them both with praise and money and encouraged them to go for formal studies to broaden their horizon. One of her confectionary manager later persuaded her to start an entire diabetic product line. As usual, after much reluctance, she plunged in but when she did, she brought in not only a diabetic line but also a low cholesterol line of products.

Mrs. Rakhi would visit each of her stores at least once in a week. When she was there, she helped in serving, cleaning up, and merchandising, which the employees had never seen before. Her managers and employees were proud to work in Sambhavi and did not wait for her orders to do that extra bit in their workplace, which literally had become their home, especially when she permitted any employee to bring their child and leave it in the kid care.

At the end of three years, she paused to take stock. She had just returned from her four weeks entrepreneur's course in the U.S and had appointed an independent auditor to do the stock taking. After her return, she spoke to several employees, managers, customers, and suppliers and wrote down her mission statement as "to enrich lives". If the consultant who did the audit was sceptical of her three word mission statement, her MBA daughter was cynical, but Mrs. Rakhi stuck to it. Her argument was simple. I created this bakery to enrich the life of me and my family. From a status of starving, we lived and prospered enriching ourselves. I enriched the lives of so many customers by providing them with very high quality products such that they used to travel long distances and then I enriched them again by setting shops near their homes. I enriched my employees and I have never forgotten to bake a

cake myself for the least of them on their birthdays (I wonder how long I can keep doing it!). I enrich the kids and teenagers who come to the shop. If I am to enrich lives how can I not be unethical, how can I delay payments to the suppliers and taxes to the society, how can I lack integrity or adulterate or use low quality ingredients and yet enrich lives? When she was rather an uneducated lady, she had inspired her employees with these simple three words. “Why would I need to change it now?” she quipped to the consultant. The consultant was dumbfounded with the power of her three word mission statement and even more by the power of her arguments.

Glancing through the report, her mind went back to the dusty and smoky bakery oven in her backyard from where she had trodden all the way. The report ended, “here, directing seems to have given way to leading. Your people have the pep, they take initiative and are ever eager to break their own records in business. The customers are almost united in their appreciation for the outlets and Sambhavi is well poised for its next growth stage of laying out several more such stores. Customers in other districts are ready.”

5.3 Definition and Comparing and Contrasting – Directing and Leading

Leading can be defined as the process of setting direction, creating alignment, and creating engagement to deliver high productivity and to facilitate change. Directing can be defined as the process by which the managers instruct, guide, and oversee the performance of the workers to achieve predetermined goals. It is the heart of management process. Planning, organising, and staffing have got no importance if direction function does not take place.

Directing initiates action and it is from here that the actual work starts. In other words, we can say that it is the way of converting decisions into actions through people. Directing has a strong human component and can be perceived as:

- A mechanism by which people are given orders using the authority and held accountable for the orders given using all means including rewards and punishments. In this sense, it has a coercive component and

submission connotation i.e., the manager coerces and the employee submits.

- It can also be perceived as a mechanism of providing guidance to workers in doing any work. In the field of management, direction is said to be all those activities, which are designed to encourage the subordinates to work effectively and efficiently. This implies support to the employee. Though it still has a component of coercion, it is much less and the submissive component is even lesser.
- Another form of directing is defined as a process or technique by which instruction can be issued and operations can be carried out as originally planned. Therefore, directing is the function of guiding, inspiring, overseeing, and instructing people towards accomplishment of organisational goals.

In all the above definitions we have not fully accepted the idea that the employee is a complete stakeholder who is brought into the vision and mission of the organisation. However, if the employees are brought into it, they along with their managers would get objectives for themselves which are in consonance with the organisational objectives. They go about fulfilling those and make efforts to surpass the objectives and the standards set. When this is done, the term directing in its conventional sense loses the meaning and it becomes leading. Towards the end of last century, several transnational organisations espoused this idea and by using knowledge as the pivot, reshaped the way work is done on the shop floor. They found that leading rather than directing, liberated the human spirit of independence and desire to meet challenging goals and surpass them. These organisations showed profits several times more than those that were still in the world of directing and they easily glided through many economic downturns. Southwest Airlines of the U.S is a classical example wherein it reported profit quarter after quarter for over 30 years without a break when every other airline was reporting loss. Closer home, Infosys did the same as also the Birla group, which in a matter of two decades transformed itself into a multi business giant.

Thus, directing and leading are not mutually exclusive, nor are they two sides of a coin. They can be perceived to be a continuum along which organisations to achieve maturity in getting work done and surpassing the

goals. Directing is therefore an essential part of leading but is insufficient to compete in the contemporary world; where leading is the key to creating competitive advantage. Here, the author cautions that there are several text books which project leading as a subset of directing but a reality check indicates that the vice versa is true.

Self Assessment Questions

1. Directing can be defined as the process by which the managers instruct, _____ and _____ the performance of the workers.
2. Directing and leading is a continuum. (True/False)
3. When an employee buys into the vision and mission, time has come for _____ rather than _____.

5.4 Characteristics of Leading

Pervasiveness

Leading is required at all levels of organisation. It is incorrect to believe that leading is required only at the top level. This is more so in the modern context where teams are the working entities. In team based working, the team leader has to act much like a CEO except that the level of working may be much smaller. He/she may be motivating a team of 5 or 10 people while the CEO may be motivating the whole company, but the function of giving targets, resources, support, motivating, etc. does not change.

Continuity

Leading is a continuous activity as it is continuous throughout the life of organisation. It takes place on a day to day basis though its importance may become higher when the organisation is undergoing a change.

Human factor

Leading implies the existence of followers much like directing implies the existence of subordinates to whom one can pass orders. It follows that there is a key human factor in leading and because human factor is complex and behaviour is unpredictable, leading function is important and people have to learn the art of leading. Further, this characteristic is based on the belief that human beings are motivated by challenging jobs and they feel a sense of achievement in doing these. The premise is also that people normally work

towards achieving the goals i.e., human being have a goal oriented behaviour.

Creativity

Leading is a creative activity because of the human factors and individual variances and group variances. In the case of Sambhavi Bakers we saw how Mrs. Rakhi was creative in enabling her staff to take leadership roles. Thus, converting her plan of having a differentiated bakery outlet is actually creatively executed by the employees. It is the creativity aspect which brings in the differentiation. It also ensures that people have to look forward to the meaning and without functions people find it difficult to find the meaning. Hence, we can see that creating functions around which people find meaning is a creative function that leads to achievements.

Executive function

Leading is carried out by all managers and executives at all levels throughout the working of an enterprise. A follower receives tasks, resources, know-how, and support from a leader and he/she trusts his/her leader to do the same. Leading implies that the followers execute the functions, which the leader and the follower agree is important for achieving the organisational goals and through it the individual goals.

Delegating function

Leading implies guiding followers to the destination. It means that the followers actually execute and if they have to execute, they need the powers for doing so. Hence, delegating is natural fallout of leading. It also follows that the leader trusts his/her followers and the vice versa. Hence, mutual trust always exists in leading. Therefore, delegating function based on mutual trust is a characteristic of leading.

Self Assessment Questions

4. Leading is required mostly at the top level. (True/False)
5. Leading is a process that we adopt when there is an urgent requirement for a change. (True/False)
6. Delegating is natural fallout of_____.

5.5 Importance of Leading

Leading or leadership function is said to be the heart of management process. Therefore, it is the central point around which accomplishment of goals take place. A few philosophers call leading as “*Life spark of an enterprise*”. It is also called as an actuating function of management because it is through direction that the operation of an enterprise actually starts. Being the central character of an enterprise, it provides many benefits to a concern which are as follows:

1. **Initiates actions** – Leading is the function which starts the work performance of the followers or subordinates. Mrs. Rakhi of Sambhavi initiated the actions by giving goals to the employees. She could have given direction, rules, and regulations. The work would perhaps still have been done but not with so much enthusiasm. Further, leading has a self-perpetuating component in that the led knows where to do and therefore, even if they take different routes, ensure that the destination is reached more efficiently and effectively. This happens because of the human characteristics discussed in earlier section where we discussed the goal-oriented behaviour under ‘human factor’. Through this function subordinates understand their jobs and work according to the guidelines and agreed methods. Plans can be implemented only when the actual work starts. Thus, leading initiates action.
2. **Sustains action** – Direction, much like leading initiates action but these directions have to be repeated if the actions have to go on. Leading on the other hand ensures that the actions go on and course corrections are done automatically by the followers because of their innate belief in the goal being something desirable to follow. When they face obstacles, they would either fall back on the leader if the obstacles are too huge to overcome. This is done when the leading process would ensure that additional resources including pooled wisdom are pumped in to resolve it.
3. **Integrates efforts** – Through leading, the superiors are able to guide, inspire, and instruct the subordinates to work. When every employee, team leader, and division leader knows that his/her reaching the goal is dependent on other's effort, there is a natural flow of inter-team and interdepartmental information. If you had been directing, this relation will

not only be forced but also monitored. Literature on directing will often speak of the need for effective communication and often communication is considered as the key to directing. The role of communication is no different in leading but communication often is tacit much like the head of Sambhavi bakers helping with sales and cleaning when she visits her outlets. Therefore, integration is much easier and far more effective through leading.

4. **Means of motivation** – Leading helps in achievement of goals. A manager makes use of the element of motivation to improve the performances of subordinates. This can be done by providing incentives or compensation, whether monetary or non-monetary, which serves as a “morale booster” to the subordinates. Motivation is also helpful for the subordinates to give the best of their abilities, which ultimately helps in growth. You saw how the employees of Sambhavi are praised and rewarded.
5. **Provides stability** – Stability and balance in a concern becomes very important for a long-term survival in the market. This can be brought upon by the managers with the help of four tools or elements of leading function - judicious blend of persuasive leadership, effective communication, clear performance goals, and efficient motivation. Stability is very important since that is an index of growth of an enterprise. Therefore, a manager can use of all the four traits in him/her so that the performance standards can be maintained.
6. **Copes with the changes** – It is a human behaviour to show resistance to change. Adaptability with changing environment helps in sustaining planned growth and becoming a market leader. It is a directing function which is of use to meet the changes in the environment, both internal and external. But when it comes to leading, there is a much natural flow to change as people automatically embrace change and adapt to their journey towards the goal. It is the role of the manager to communicate the nature and contents of changes required for reaching the goal very clearly to the subordinates. This helps in clarifications, easy adaptations, and smooth running of an enterprise. For example, Sambhavi shifted from a single outlet to multi-outlets, which means several changes at all levels. Mrs. Rakhi’s earlier employees would not have seen the merchandise or kid care. Yet their goal of providing a great service eggs

them on. Let us take the case of a handloom shifting to power loom. This is an important change in the technique of production. The resulting factors are less of manpower and more of machinery. This can be resisted by the subordinates. The manager can explain that the change was in the benefit of the subordinates. Through more mechanisation, production increases and thereby the profits. Indirectly, the subordinates benefit in the form of higher remuneration and better quality of life. If you were directing, you will explain it in this way but if you were leading, you will talk about the automation, employees' children going to good schools and studying abroad because of the higher income, the modern facilities and healthier environment and better health and less diseases, etc. Here the individual and organisational goals are merged using motivation and communication while in the former the effort is still the same but without a vivid description of the goal. The former makes it far less effective.

7. ***Utilises resources efficiently*** – Leading through goal setting helps in clarifying the role of every subordinate towards his work. The resources can be utilised properly only when less of wastages, duplication of efforts, overlapping of performances, etc. don't take place. Through the goal setting, the role of subordinates becomes clear as managers make use of their supervisory skills, the guidance, the instructions and motivation skill to inspire the subordinates. This helps in maximum possible utilisation of resources of men, machine, materials, and money, which helps in reducing costs and increasing profits.

From the above discussion, one can justify that leading, surely, is the heart of management process. Heart plays an important role in a human body as it serves the function of pumping blood to all parts of the body. In a similar manner, leading helps the subordinates to perform in the best of their abilities and that too in a healthy environment. The manager makes use of the four elements of direction so that work can be accomplished in a proper and right manner. According to Earnest Dale, "Directing is what has to be done and in what manner through dictating the procedures and policies for accomplishing performance standards." You can reword Earnest Dale and say that through leading, people accomplish goals even without dictating. Hence, leading is the essence of management process.

Self Assessment Questions

7. A few philosophers call _____ as “*Life spark of an enterprise*”.
8. _____ makes the role of subordinates clear.
9. While both directing and leading are important, directing is a much better way to sustain action. (True/False)

5.6 Role and Functions of Leading**Functions of leading**

Leading is an essential management process. The three main functions of leading are as follows:

- Setting direction
- Creating alignment
- Creating engagement

Now we also saw that in organisations there are leaders at various levels. In general, they are classified as top, middle, and lower management. Therefore, it is easier to look at the three leading functions at these three levels.

Let us now study the functions in detail.

Setting direction

Direction setting can be defined as ‘fixing the purpose and the mission of an organisation along with the values’. Simply put, it is about creating a vision statement.

Usually the top executives set the direction in an organisation. But it has to be bought into by the employees. Usually, we see people running mission statement exercises and vision retreats. Sambhavi’s owner had quietly talked to people and got at it. Her job is to make this clear so that other actions such as planning, organising, and staffing can get going. She did that in no uncertain terms. But how does her outlet manager do it? Does he/she also set a direction? Well, usually we say that he/she should set goals based on the direction. What about the merchandise manager or the service manager? They too should set their objectives and targets. We often perceive direction setting, goal setting, and arriving at objectives as different. The only difference is that direction setting is broader and lacks

specifics but is very inspiring. Goals set by the outlet manager (let us consider a middle level manager) are of course more specific with figures such as 'merchandise should increase the revenue by 20% each quarter'. But the problem with this specific statement is that it is not so inspiring and therefore not so sustainable and hence has to co-ride with the mission statement or the direction itself. Now let us get to the goals set by Assistant Manager. He/she too would set objective such as 'to sell worth Rs. 20,000 a day'. The figures in the target are more specific and time bound.

As we go from middle management to the lower management, the goals or objectives get SMARTer (Specific, Measurable, Attainable, Realistic, and Time bound) . Yet they become dumper in their power to inspire. Now this is the difference between directing and leading. In directing, we give SMART goals and objectives but in leading we pep it with inspiration. So perhaps if you were leading an organisation you would say 'I will enrich 20 lives today by selling the merchandise worth Rs. 20,000 to them'. Thus we see that direction setting is science but leading is an art with strong scientific basis. If we look at leading as management function and direction setting as its sub-function, then we should remember that leading means injecting that inspirational spirit with every direction setting action that you do.

Direction setting and directing are different. Leaders set direction which are broad and point towards where we have to move. On the other hand, directing is a set of orders that are given based on direction setting to execute the direction set. Directions lack flexibility and the one who issues it has to change it. Direction setting has full flexibility as the employees work in different ways but in the same direction. Direction setting is much more difficult to communicate and needs people who are genuine in heart and enthusiastic to learn but it brings rich dividend. As organisations grow and become global in service industry where both the product delivery and consumption is done together by the employee and the customer, the need for flexibility is so high that 'directing' has perhaps become antithesis to good service delivery and has to replace 'leading'.

Creating alignment

Creating alignment can be defined as 'making the organisation act in unions with the mission statement'. As a sub-function of leading, we ensure that people understand the mission and goal and show willingness to align their

personal missions and goals with the organisational mission just like what many employees of Sambhavi had done. This of course is the onus of the top management and the employees.

Aligning the product portfolio – The product and services of the organisation are in tune with the mission and the customers understand that this is what is being delivered so that the value proposition is clear. At the top management level this means deciding on the product portfolio, at the middle management it means product improvement and innovation, which makes the product more aligned and at the lower level it means adhering to the quality and processes, fine tuning the processes and contributing ideas to enrich the processes and products.

Aligning the delivery – At the top management level, this means identifying the right segment and matching the segment and the product proposition. At the middle level it means enabling the customers to procure the product and service by having appropriate distribution system, information process, etc. At the lower level, it means service leadership by faultless delivery, prompt support, providing feedback to the customers and the management. It also means that the production aligns its scheduling, purchase aligns its purchasing, etc.

Aligning the HR process – At the top level, it means the way people are treated, how coaching is done and growth is enabled and trust is created through communication. At the middle level, it is about being fair, transparent, equitable, empathetic, and about translating the top management policies into actions. At the lower level, it is about striving to excel and being committed.

Creating engagement

Engagement can be defined as 'capturing the mind space of the stake holders'. It connects the individual to the organisation. If the purpose of directing is to get faultless actions from an employee, the purpose of leading is to get faultless, flexible, proactive, and sustained actions from an employee.

We use the analogy of the family in business very often and say that employees should be treated like family members. What this means is that

setting direction and aligning can be sustainable only if we engage people because it is the engagement which results in selfless actions.

The top management achieves engagement by creating high performance work arrangement, recruiting, and nurturing exceptional talent (as applicable to the company). The middle management creates engagement through shop floor actions of creating trust, giving feedback, supporting development by sending people to various programmes, job rotation, employing people in jobs that are challenging to them and coaching.

The lower management engages its employees by giving day to day guidance, listening to their opinions, having shop floor committees like quality circles, being empathetic, ensuring safer work environment, educating on safety, interpreting and explaining policies, and executing the policies in a fair, equitable, and impartial manner as also given opportunity to vent their feelings and grievances.

Irrespective of the level of management, all leaders have to be involved in direction setting, creating alignment, and creating engagement. Their role and the time they spend in these may vary depending on the level. Leading cannot be successful unless all these functions are addressed. In the end, it is important to reiterate that directing is an essential component of good management but contemporary organisations are not satisfied with it but they look at leading as the tool to create highly successful organisations.

Roles of leading

Leading is a function that every manager and supervisor does in an organisation. So, what could be the role of leading? First people fill up the role in various activities (organising) and only then the process of leading commences. Some of the important roles of a leader are:

- **Planning role** – A leader takes the planning role at various levels. Whether you are the CEO or a supervisor at the shop floor, this role is inevitable. At the lower levels this implies dividing the work to various workers according to their abilities.
- **Managing role** – Everyone has to undertake the managing role which implies fulfilling the management functions that we have studied earlier. Here too depending on the level, we may have different activities e.g., the CEO may be managing the macro resources while the shop floor team leader may be managing the HR and inventory of the day.

- **Guiding role** – As mentioned above, a CEO would be guiding the strategy, and other actions while a supervisor guides his/her co-worker and subordinates on how to optimise their productivity.
- **Mediator** – While the CEO mediates with the board and external clients, the lower level leaders mediate with the immediate superiors, customers, suppliers, subordinates, etc.
- **Inspector role** – Every manager irrespective of his/her level has to inspect so that he/she can control the variance and ensure that discipline is maintained in day to day activities and productivity. While the CEO may be inspecting the plant, its total safety, return on investment, sales targets etc., the lower level leaders may be inspecting whether a person wears a helmet, uses the right tools, etc.
- **Counselling role** – While a CEO acts as a counsel to the top management and their personal problems, the lower level manager would do that to the employee.

Activity:

Browse internet and find out the employer engagement strategies followed in Infosys. Make a list of the methods used.

Hint. Refer Section 5.6

Self Assessment Questions

10. Three fundamental functions of leading are selling direction, creating alignment and _____.
11. Direction setting means defining the goals and objectives. (True/False)
12. Engagement can be defined as capturing the _____ of stakeholders.

5.7 Summary

Let us recapitulate the important concepts discussed in this unit:

- Leading is an important management function/process. It is the process by which plans are converted into actions. Once called directing, the process has undergone considerable changes since organisations began to find that mere direction is not sufficient to elicit high productivity

from people. People have to be involved and therefore the importance of leading came to the fore.

- Leading, as a function, has three important components - direction setting, aligning, and creating engagement.
- People tend to forget the direction of the organisation in the heat of excitement and tend to waiver from the mission. Once we do that, the alignment is lost as also the engagement. As a result, the organisation slowly slips from its high pedestal and therefore there is a constant need to monitor. Equally, leading is perhaps the only way by which change can be brought into the organisation.
- The important role of a leader are planning, managing, guiding, mediating, inspecting and counselling.

5.8 Glossary

- **Aligning:** Making the organisation act in union with the mission statement.
- **Directing:** Process by which the managers instruct, guide, and oversee the performance of the workers to achieve predetermined goals.
- **Direction setting:** Fixing the purpose, mission, and values of an organisation.
- **Engagement:** Capturing the mind space of the stakeholders.
- **Leading:** Process of setting direction, creating alignment, and creating engagement to deliver high productivity and facilitate change.

5.9 Terminal Questions

1. Define the concept of leading.
2. What are the characteristics of leading ?
3. Why is leading important ?
4. What are the main functions of leading ?

5.9 Answers

Self Assessment Questions

1. guide, and oversee
2. True
3. Leading, directing
4. False
5. False
6. Leading
7. Leading
8. Goal setting
9. False
10. Direction setting, creating engagement and creating alignment
11. False
12. Mind space

Terminal Questions

1. Leading is the process of setting direction, creating alignment and creating engagement to deliver high productivity and to facilitate change. Refer Section 5.3
2. The major characteristics are pervasiveness, continuity, creativity, executive function, delegation. Refer Section 5.4
3. Leading is important as it initiates and sustains action, integrates efforts, motivates and provides stability. Refer Section 5.5
4. Major functions are setting direction, creating alignment and creating engagement. Refer Section 5.6

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